SEAT BELT BUCKLE INSPECTION AND/OR REPLACEMENT PROCEDURE

AFFECTED VEHICLES: **CERTAIN 2001 MODEL YEAR CROWN VICTORIA, EXCURSION, EXPEDITION, F-150, F-250 THROUGH 550, GRAND MARQUIS, NAVIGATOR, RANGER, TOWN CAR AND WINDSTAR**

OVERVIEW

Only some of the affected vehicles are expected to need seat belt buckle replacement. This document contains the necessary information for inspecting and, if necessary, replacing the **driver and/or passenger front seat belt buckle assembly(s)** on the affected vehicles. Center seat belt buckles are **not** affected. A special tool has been developed to identify possibly defective buckles and make sure the inspection of the buckle mechanism is consistent. Although the special tool has been developed to identify 100% of the potentially faulty buckles, it can also identify good buckles as defective. This is acceptable in order to ensure **ALL** defective buckles are identified. If the tool rejects **any** buckle, it must be replaced. This document also contains amendments to the Workshop Manual sections related to buckle replacement. **Be sure to read this document before attempting to replace the seat belt buckles.**

INSPECTION

WARNING: CYCLE THE GAUGE COMPLETELY FOR EACH TEST. FAILURE TO FULLY CYCLE THE GAUGE BY LEAVING IT IN THE FULLY EXTENDED POSITION (ROTATED CLOCKWISE TO THE STOP) AND MANUALLY INSERTING THE TOOL INTO THE BUCKLE CAN RESULT IN ACCEPTING BAD BUCKLES AS GOOD BUCKLES. FOLLOW THESE INSTRUCTIONS TO PREVENT ACCEPTING ANY BAD BUCKLES AS GOOD.

1. NOTE: Make sure that the knob on the special tool is fully unscrewed (the gauge tongue is retracted) before installing it on the buckle.

Slowly press and release the red seat belt release button located on the driver side seat belt buckle. Then, install the special tool onto the driver side seat belt buckle and hold it in place. See Figure 1.

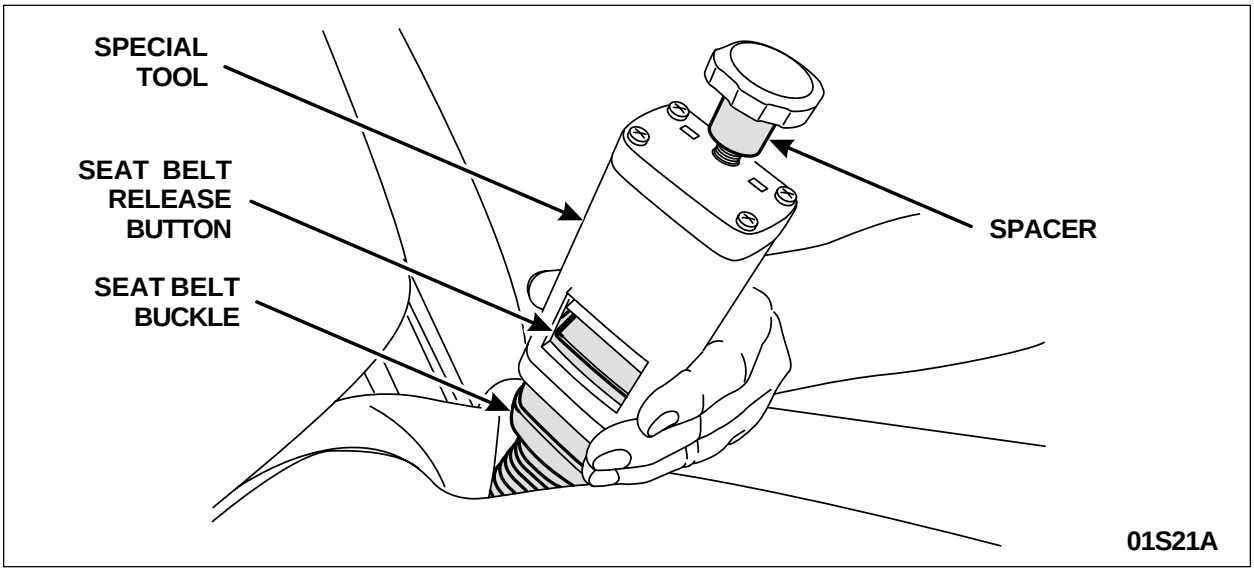


FIGURE 1

Ford Motor Company
CPR © 2001 FORD MOTOR COMPANY
DEARBORN, MICHIGAN 48121
07/01

2. **WARNING: MAKE SURE YOU TURN THE KNOB ON THE SPECIAL TOOL SMOOTHLY BY HAND IN THIS STEP. FAILURE TO DO SO MAY RESULT IN A DEFECTIVE BUCKLE PASSING INSPECTION.**

   NOTE: When the gauge tongue is near the end of its travel, the buckle is likely to make a "click" sound. Do not stop turning the knob at this point. Disregard the click and continue to turn the knob until it bottoms out. Do not try to tighten the knob once it reaches the stop.

   While holding the special tool in place, turn the knob on the special tool until it bottoms out. If resistance is felt while turning the knob on the special tool, it may require lubrication. Lubricate the threads on the knob shaft with Lubriplate® (130-AA) white grease or similar white lithium grease. See Figure 2.

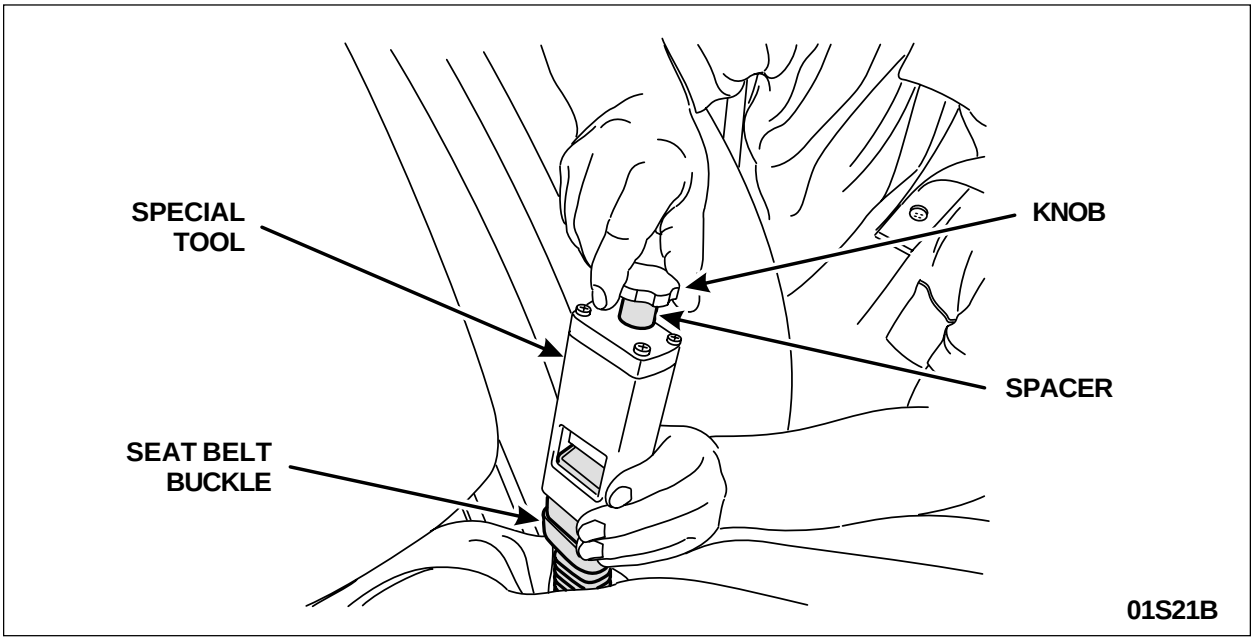


FIGURE 2

3. Pull on the body of the special tool in an attempt to remove it from the belt buckle. Do this without pressing the red seat belt release button. **DO NOT PULL ON THE KNOB OF THE SPECIAL TOOL DURING BUCKLE INSPECTION AS THIS MAY DAMAGE THE TOOL**.
   - If the special tool **does not** stay locked into place in the belt buckle, but instead disengages from the belt buckle, the belt buckle must be replaced. Refer to the Service Procedure section of this document for instruction.
   - If the special tool **does** stay locked into place in the belt buckle and cannot be disengaged without depressing the red seat belt release button, the belt buckle does not need to be replaced.
4. Depress the red seat belt release button to remove the special tool from the seat belt buckle. After removal, unscrew the knob completely. ***Do not attempt to unscrew the knob until the tool is removed from the belt buckle or damage will result.***
5. Repeat Steps 1-4 on the passenger side seat belt buckle.

Ford Motor Company
CPR © 2001 FORD MOTOR COMPANY
DEARBORN, MICHIGAN 48121
07/01

SERVICE PROCEDURE

NOTE: All Workshop Manual references in this document are to the June 2001 CD version.

CROWN VICTORIA, GRAND MARQUIS AND TOWN CAR

1. Replace the affected front row seat belt buckle(s). Refer to the service procedures in section 501-20A of the appropriate CD for the vehicle being serviced.

EXCURSION AND F-250 THROUGH 550

1. Replace the affected front row seat belt buckle(s). Refer to the service procedures in section 501-20A of the appropriate CD for the vehicle being serviced, with the following exceptions for manual 60/40 split bench and manual captain's chair:
   A. On vehicles equipped with captain's chairs, the driver seat must be removed from the vehicle. Refer to the service procedures in section 501-10 of the appropriate CD for the vehicle being serviced.
   B. The following steps must be performed to remove the driver seat belt buckle from the seat on captain's chairs and 40 percent seats of the 60/40 split bench seats.
      - Remove the rear mounting bolt from the inboard seat track.
      - Remove the buckle retaining nut.
      - Position the rear of the inboard seat track away from the seat frame for clearance to remove the electrical connector. See Figure 3.

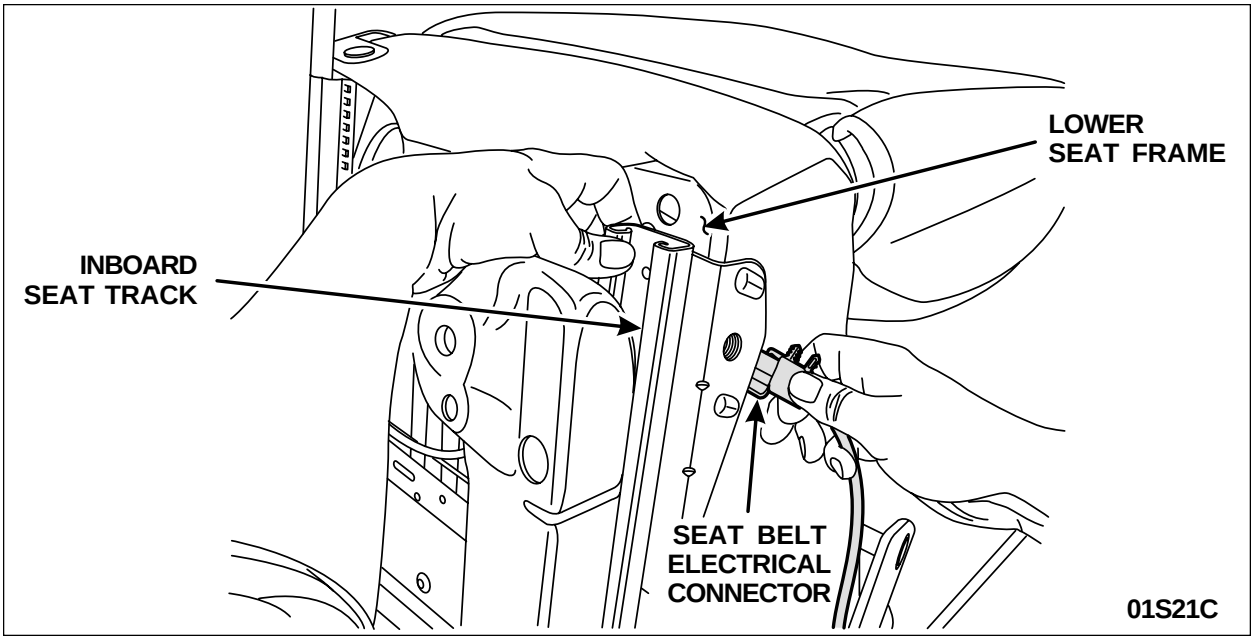


FIGURE 3

- Remove the buckle and route the electrical connector through the side of the lower seat frame.
- For installation, reverse the steps above. Tighten the seat track bolt to 25 Nm (19 lb-ft) and the belt buckle nut to 40 Nm (30 lb-ft).

Ford Motor Company

CPR © 2001 FORD MOTOR COMPANY
DEARBORN, MICHIGAN 48121
07/01

EXPEDITION AND NAVIGATOR

1. Replace the affected front row seat belt buckle(s). Refer to the service procedures in section 501-20A of the appropriate CD for the vehicle being serviced.

F-150

1. Replace the affected front row seat belt buckle(s). Refer to the service procedures in section 501-20A of the appropriate CD for the vehicle being serviced, with the following exceptions:
   - For vehicles with 60/40 split bench seats equipped with Seat Integrated Restraint (SIR) systems: During seat belt buckle removal, the 60 percent seat cushion does not have to be removed to access the seat belt buckle bolt.
   - For vehicles equipped with SIR: During seat removal, position the seat forward to access the fifth foot trim cover fastener.

RANGER

1. Replace the affected front row seat belt buckle(s). Refer to the service procedures in section 501-20A of the appropriate CD for the vehicle being serviced, with the following exceptions:
   - Remove both center seat belt bolts and leave the belts attached to the seat during removal.
   - During seat installation, it is not necessary to route the center seat belts through the locating strap since they are still attached to the seat. Tighten both bolts to 40 Nm (30 lb-ft).

WINDSTAR

1. Replace the affected front row seat belt buckle(s). Refer to the service procedures in section 501-20A of the appropriate CD for the vehicle being serviced.

Ford Motor Company

CPR © 2001 FORD MOTOR COMPANY
DEARBORN, MICHIGAN 48121
07/01